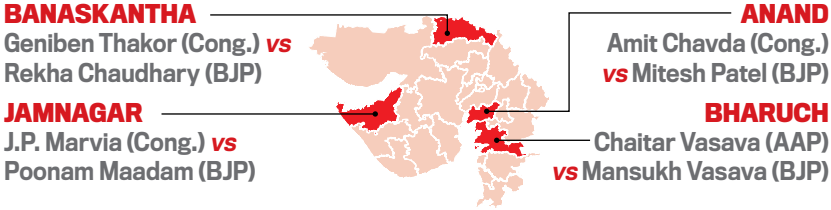


HOME RUN Gandhinagar candidate Amit Shah at a roadshow in Kalol

THE TIGHT CONTESTS



where simultaneous bypolls will be held on May 7. Meanwhile, Paresh Dhanani, who had refused to contest from Rajkot, has consented after the fuss over Rupala broke out in the BJP.

But the Congress was still to hit its nadir this poll season. On the last day of filing nominations, the forms of its Surat candidate Nilesh Kumbhani and that of the dummy nominee were rejected after four proposers backed out saying their signatures had been forged. Soon enough, the remaining seven candidates in withdrew their nominations too and the BJP contestant Mukesh Dalal was declared winner unopposed. Meanwhile, Kumbhani went incommunicado, as rumours of him joining the BJP gained momentum.

As for the BJP, the Patidar community (14 per cent of the population) remains its most steadfast supporter with a decisive role in at least 10 Lok Sabha seats. With Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel now the face of the 'double engine *sarkar*', the Patidars have also moved past the demand for reservation. The other major constituent are the tribals (14.7 per cent) who, disillusioned with the Congress, seem to be shifting loyalties saffronwards—the BJP won 23 of the 27 tribal seats in the 2022 assembly elections—though ground reports suggest they haven't quite settled into the new equation yet. Two young tribal leaders are gaining traction—AAP's Dediapada MLA Chaitar Vasava, who is contesting from Bharuch, and the Congress's Vansda MLA Anant Patel from Valsad. Muslims constitute about 10 per cent of the vote but are caught in a no-man's land. Peddling soft Hindutva, the Congress has gone cold on them, while the BJP will not attempt an overt outreach.

Farmers across the state find agriculture unsustainable, but draw heart from the fact that land prices have skyrocketed due to urban development and industrial projects. Many have bought land elsewhere and continued farming, but several have also migrated to urban centres and are struggling. Former deputy sarpanch of Shahpur village in Gandhinagar, 70-year-old Isha Solanki, appears weary about the politics of the day, even if she concedes that "Modi is a good man". She points to her 19-year-old grandson who is looking for a job but can't find any. Her husband and former BJP officebearer Kalubhai is quiet.

Meanwhile, Gandhinagar candidate Amit Shah and Modi hit the road to campaign with less than 10 days to go for the polls. At a public gathering in Godhra, the ground zero of the 2002 communal riots, Shah invoked the communal fault-lines again, recalling the sacrifice of the 54 *kar sevak*s who had sacrificed their lives for the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya. However, veteran sociologist Prof. Ghanshyam Shah feels that Hindutva isn't top of the agenda for a large section anymore. "Research shows that some 77 per cent of Hindus in Gujarat feel that what happened in 2002 was not right. The BJP is well aware of this and does a constant *jugalbandi* of economic development and polarisation. There is dissatisfaction, even the BJP cadre are restless," he says. But then there's also TINA.

The Congress narrative is focused on '*Anyay Kaal vs Amrut Kaal*'. "We are talking about real issues like inflation and unemployment," claims party spokesperson Manish Doshi. The party's internal analysts, though, confide that they are realistically looking at just four seats—Bharuch, Banaskantha, Jamnagar and Anand. For the main opposition to concede that its contest is limited to 15 per cent of the battle arena is perhaps leaving the field open for the dominant player. It's not the ideal situation in a democracy, but that is the reality of Gujarat. ■